

National Coverage Determination (NCD)

Alpha-fetoprotein

190.25

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Tracking Information

Publication Number

100-3

Manual Section Number

190.25

Manual Section Title

Alpha-fetoprotein

Version Number

1

Effective Date of this Version

11/25/2002

Implementation Date

01/01/2003

Description Information

Benefit Category

Diagnostic Laboratory Tests

Please Note: This may not be an exhaustive list of all applicable Medicare benefit categories for this item or service.

Item/Service Description

AFP is a polysaccharide found in some carcinomas. It is effective as a biochemical marker for monitoring the response of certain malignancies to therapy.

Indications and Limitations of Coverage

Indications

AFP is useful for the diagnosis of hepatocellular carcinoma in high-risk patients (such as alcoholic cirrhosis, cirrhosis of viral etiology, hemochromatosis, and alpha 1-antitrypsin deficiency) and in separating patients with benign hepatocellular neoplasms or metastases from those with hepatocellular carcinoma and, as a non-specific tumor associated antigen, serves in marking germ cell neoplasms of the testis, ovary, retroperitoneum, and mediastinum.

Note: Scroll down for links to the quarterly Covered Code Lists (including narrative).

Cross Reference

Also see the [Medicare Claims Processing Manual](#), Chapter 120, Clinical Laboratory Services Based on Negotiated Rulemaking.

Transmittal Information

Transmittal Number

17

Coverage Transmittal Link

<https://www.cms.gov/Regulations-and-Guidance/Guidance/Transmittals/Downloads/R17NCD.pdf>

Revision History

07/2004 - Published NCD in the NCD Manual without change to narrative contained in PM AB-02-110. Coding guidance now published in Medicare Lab NCD Manual. Effective and Implementation dates NA. ([TN 17](#)) (CR 2130)

07/2002 - Implemented NCD. Effective date 11/25/02. Implementation date 1/01/03. ([TN AB-02-110](#)) (CR 2130)

Other

Covered Code Lists (including narrative)

January 2026 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))

October 2025 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))

January 2025 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))

October 2024 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))

July 2024 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))

April 2024 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))

January 2024 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
October 2023 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
July 2023 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
April 2023 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
January 2023 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
October 2022 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
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April 2022 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
January 2022 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
October 2021 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
July 2021 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
April 2021 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
January 2021 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
October 2020 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
July 2020 (PDF) ([ICD-10](#))
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January 2017 ([ICD-10](#))
October 2016 ([ICD-10](#))
January 2016 ([ICD-10](#))
October 2015 ([ICD-10](#), [ICD-9](#))
October 2014 ([ICD-10](#), [ICD-9](#))

Changes to Lab NCD Edit Software

[January 2026](#)
[October 2025](#)
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- [January 2017](#)
- [January 2016](#)
- [October 2014](#)

Additional Information

Other Versions

Title	Version	Effective Between	
Alpha-fetoprotein	1	11/25/2002 - N/A	You are here